Scammed!

By: Bhaskar Bhattacharya

Characters:

Anirudh: Indian male about 26 year old

Entities: Unknown Humanoids

INT. ROOFTOP ROOM - EVENING

Scene is dark and we hear phone conversation between two people. Camera slowly fades in to Anirudh's face as the dialogue progresses.

ANIRUDH
Hello, main Inspector Vijaya bol rha hu CBI ke Cybercrime Division se. Kya meri baat Mr. Sahaj Patel se ho rhi hai?

CALLEE
Ji mera hi naam hai.

ANIRUDH
Patelji, aap meri baat dhyaan se sunein aur call disconnect na karein. Aapke khilaaf serious charges hain aur filhaal aap under investigation hain.

CALLEE
Kya baat kar rhe hain?

ANIRUDH
Ji, ek overseas bank account mila hai jisse aapka phone number aur PAN linked hai. Us account se pandrah crore se zyada ke fraudulent transactions hue hain. Aur—

CALLEE
Bhai sahab kya bole ja rhe hain? Mera koi overseas account hai hi nhi.

ANIRUDH
Aapka address Anand Vihaar, Noida ka hai, aur aapka PAN number bhi usi account se linked hai.

CALLEE
Lekin sir itna bada allegation aise hi laga rhe hain aap.

ANIRUDH
Filhaal aap investigation me cooperate kijiye. Kyonki aapke naam pe arrest warrant hai.

CALLEE
Arre nhi sir, mujhe fasaya ja rha hai. Mere naam pe aaj tak chaalaan tak nhi kata, aap arrest warrant ki baat kar rhe hain.

ANIRUDH
Dekhiye isi liye keh rha hu, aap cooperate kijiye. Mai secondary verification ka process start kar rha hu. Mai aapse kuch details poochunga records se match karane ke liye, theek hai?

CALLEE
Theek hai sir.

ANIRUDH
Aapka poora naam Sahaj Kumar Patel hai, right?

CALLEE
Ji.

ANIRUDH
Apna Date of Birth bataiye.

CALLEE
22nd March, 1965.

ANIRUDH
Theek hai. Ab aapke mobile pe ek verification code aayega. Woh mujhe bata dijiye.

Anirudh initiates Marauder Script.

ANIRUDH
Check kijiye.

CALLEE
Ji... 5182...(Inaudible)

ANIRUDH
Theek hai Patelji. Mai aapka arrest warrant hold pe daal rha hu. 24 ghante tak aap kisi se contact nhi kar sakte hain, samjhe aap?

CALLEE
Ji

ANIRUDH
Chaliye. Shubh ratri.

Satisfied. Anirudh hangs up. Marks lead as "Harvest Complete". He leans back on his chair and checks time. Suddenly his phone rings. Caller ID says Supervisor sir.

ANIRUDH
Hanji sir?

SUPERVISOR
Han Anirudh, ek updated list share kiya hai tumko.

ANIRUDH
Um- check kar rha hu sir.

SUPERVISOR
Check karke batao kitne leads hain total?

ANIRUDH
30 hain sir.

SUPERVISOR
20 Harvest chahiye. Ho jaayega?

ANIRUDH
20 Harvest?

SUPERVISOR
Minimum 20.

ANIRUDH
Hmm...

SUPERVISOR
Ek high value target hai. Uska Document alag se hai. Call karne se pehle dekh lena jaroor.

ANIRUDH
Hanji bilkul.

SUPERVISOR
Chalo shuru kar do.

Anirudh he cracks his fingers. Pick the first target in the list. Dials the number using the CRM tool. The call connects after a few seconds.

CALLEE
Hello?

ANIRUDH
Hello, main Inspector Vijaya bol rha hu CBI ke Cybercrime Division se. Kya meri baat Mr. Gopiraj se ho rhi hai?

CALLEE
Ji nhi, mai unka beta bol rha hu. Kya chahiye aapko?

ANIRUDH
Gopiraj ji ko phone dijiyega. Mujhe unse hi baat karni hai.

CALLEE
Pitaji busy hain. Aap mujhse hi baat kijiye.

ANIRUDH
Gopiraj ji busy hain? Aur jinse baat ho rhi hai unka naam?

CALLEE
Aapki baat desh ke Pradhaan Mantri se ho rhi hai.

ANIRUDH
Ye kaun sa tareeka hai baat karne ka, han? Tumhaare pitaji jail jaane waale hain aur tumko mazak soojh rha hai?

CALLEE
Accha? Kis khushi mein jail jayenge woh?

ANIRUDH
CBI ki investigation hai. Case details tumhaare saath share nahi kar sakta. Gopiraj ji ko phone dijiye, please.

CALLEE
Dekho phone toh nhi de rha mai.

ANIRUDH
Theek hai. Investigation mein interference karne ke jurm me tumhaare against bhi warrant issue karwa deta hu.

CALLEE
(Laughs)
Itna aukaat hai kya tumhara?

ANIRUDH
Abhi toh aur hasi aayegi. Tere naam pe itne cases khlunga na, gin nhi paayega.

CALLEE
Aur tere naam pe OnlyFans kholunga. Bees rupaye mein mujra karwaunga tujhse saale.

ANIRUDH
Tu government officer se battameezi kar raha hai. Samajh nahi aa raha tujhe kya hoga.

CALLEE
Arre ja jo ukhaarna hai ukhaar le.
Bohot dekhe hain tere jaise.

ANIRUDH
Ruk. Batata hu tujhe—

Call disconnects abruptly cutting Anirudh off. He mutters something to himself angrily while shaking his fist. Silence for few seconds.

Suddenly there is a loud thud outside his room. He is startled. He grabs a stick and his mobile. Turns on flashlight and goes outside his room. There is a wooden chair outside which has toppled. He goes outside and sits it up again. The chair now casts a shadow into the room through the door.

He relaxes and then returns to his workstation to mark the lead as failed. Checks another lead and hesitates for some time. Then he takes a deep breath and starts calling the numbers. CALL MONTAGE BEGINS.

ANIRUDH
(Montage repeat)
Hello, Inspector Vijaya bol rha hu
CBI, Cybercrime division se

ANIRUDH
(Montage Cuts)
Kya meri baat Mr. Piyush se ho rhi
hai?
Kya meri baat Mrs. Payal se ho rhi
hai?
Kya meri baat Mohd. Sarfaraaz se
ho rhi hai?

ANIRUDH
(Montage Cuts)
Aapke against serious charges
hain.
Aapke naam pe illegal transfers
hue hain.

ANIRUDH
(Montage Cuts)
Verification code share kijiye.
Verification code aaya hoga aapko.
Verification code ko padhiye.

INT. ROOFTOP ROOM - LATE EVENING

Anirudh looks at the Sheet and the next person is named as Mahutila Surashendu, note beside his name says: Ex-Diplomat, High Value Target, Refer Doc-13 for more intel. Anirudh opens Doc-13 and it has some information like: Possible off-shore accounts. Previously booked for unverified money transfers, released due to lack of evidence. Associated with with Sleeper blocks and was investigated under UAPA, results inconclusive. Mention of term Outpost-225 in several old intelligence reports. No information regarding what that is.

After reading the doc he checks the number. His number is 112005116.

ANIRUDH
Ab ye kaisa number hai?

He asks himself as he dials it. Call connects after few seconds.

CALLEE
Hello

ANIRUDH
Hello, main Inspector Vijaya bol rha hu CBI ke Cybercrime Division se. Kya meri baat Mr. uh-Mahutila se ho rhi hai?

CALLEE
Ji bol rha hu.

ANIRUDH
Mahutilaji aapke naam ka ek previous case reopen hua hai. Toh usi ke baare me mujhe aapse kuch sawaal poochne hain.

CALLEE
Mr. Jo bhi naam hai aapka. I used to be a Diplomat, okay? Aise call pe kaun si government agency threaten karti hai? You think I am an idiot?

ANIRUDH
Careful Mr. Mahutila, humein underestimate karne ki galti mat kijiyega. We know everything about your past.

CALLEE
Nonsense! You know absolutely nothing.

ANIRUDH
We know about your offshore accounts and your association with Sleeper cells. We can do more damage to your reputation than you think.

CALLEE
You are just wasting my time. Kisi aur ke saath jaake time pass kijiye.

ANIRUDH
What if I tell you that I know everything about Outpost Two Twenty Five.

CALLEE
(Few seconds silence)
Sorry, come again?

ANIRUDH
I said mujhe Outpost Two Two Five ke baare me sab kuch pata hai.

CALLEE
(Again few seconds silence)
Hmm... Call me on my secure line. Note kijiye number-005172007.

Call disconnects. Anirudh is shaking a bit. He dials the number that callee gave him. Call connects.

ANIRUDH
Hello?

CALLEE
Hanji, iss line se connect karwane ka ek hi purpose hai, aapko batana ki there is a certain line you should not cross.

ANIRUDH
Aye! Dhamkane ki koshish kar rha hai tu mujhe?

CALLEE
Oh no not at all. Please enjoy the music I will be right back.

ANIRUDH
What?

Strange high pitched mechanical noise blurts from the speaker. Anirudh move the phone away from himself. Slowly brings it closer. The noise continues for sometime. Then stops.

ANIRUDH
Hello?

CALLEE
I hope you enjoyed the music.

ANIRUDH
Kya tha woh?

CALLEE
Oh nothing to worry about. Have a nice day.

Before Anirudh can say something call disconnects. He sinks his face into his hands and stays like that for a while.

Camera slowly pans and we can see that there is a shadow of a person sitting on the chair. Then, there is a single knock/tap on a nearby door. Anirudh raises his head up and looks to his side. Notices the shadow. The shadow gets up and leaves to the right.

Anirudh is alarmed. He grabs his flashlight and checks outside through the door. A shawl of some sort is suspended from the wire on the right side of the roof. At a distance feet of a person is barely visible emerging near a wall turn at the end of the roof. It slowly pulls backwards.

Anirudh sees absolutely nothing. Scratches his head and returns back to his workstation and this time he rotates his chair slightly to keep and eye on the door.

Then starts calling people again. Next person is Shubhankar from Kolkata. He dials the number and call connects.

CALLEE
Hello, ke?

ANIRUDH
Hello, main Inspector Vijaya bol rha hu CBI ke Cybercrime Division se. Kya meri baat Mr. Shubhankar se ho rhi hai?

CALLEE
(Speaks to someone else nearby)
Arre jaani na, bolche CBI theke, 1 min.

ANIRUDH
Hello Shubhankar ji?

CALLEE
Ji ji bataiye.

ANIRUDH
Shubhankar ji mujhe ek case file pa assign kiya gaya hai jispe ki aapka naam saamne aaya hai. Hello?

Some commotion is audible on the other side.

CALLEE
(Speaks to someone else nearby)
Arre darao na, kotha bolchi toh.

ANIRUDH
Shubhankarji! Kya aap meri baat pe thoda focus karenge please?

CALLEE
(Speaks sternly)
Arre kaun Shubhankar? Mai Gopiraj bol rha hu. Aapko baat karni tha na mujhse?

ANIRUDH
Gopiraj? Meri Shubhankarji se baat ho rhi thi na? Ye kisko call lag gaya? Hello Shubhankarji?

CALLEE
(Voice slightly garbled)
Arre bhai sahab mai Gopiraj baat kar rha hu. Aapki baat hui thi mere bete se.

Confused Anirudh checks the number again. The call log shows Shubhankar.

ANIRUDH
Ye log toh Shubhankar hi dikha rha hai. Kisko call lag gaya?

He checks the number and speaks again.

CALLEE
Hello?

ANIRUDH
Hello? Shubhankarji?

CALLEE
Arre dada aapko mujhse baat karna hai ya Gopiraj ji se aap ye clear kijiiye na?

ANIRUDH
Kya? Gopiraj ji hain kya aapke saath wahan?

CALLEE
Nhi nhi Gopiraj ji toh aapke udhar hain.

ANIRUDH
(Extremely confused)
Kyyaa?

CALLEE
(Speaking slowly)
Ji, aapke room ke bahar... wait kar rhe hain woh aapka.

At the corner of his eye just outside his door/window he notices a hand holding the metal grill, standing just outside his door/window. But the moment he looks at the hand it pulls backward.

Alarmed Anirudh drops his headphone, grabs his stick and turns on flashlight.

ANIRUDH
(Exclaims)
Kaun hai!

Opens his door and barges outside. Looks to the left, nothing. Looks to the right, the shawl hanging from the wire now seems like a person. Anirudh carefully approaches the formation. As he comes close enough he swings his stick hard and fast and the shawl comes off and falls to the ground. There is no human. He then lifts it up and hangs it back on the wire.

ANIRUDH
Saala, kya ho rha hai ye mere saath?

Anirudh stands scratching his head for a second and then slowly returns to his room.

He steps inside with the flashlight off. The moment he looks inside he sees a human figure just next to his PC. Scared he quickly turns on his flashlight and sees that its just a shirt suspended on his pedestal fan.

He then pulls out a padlock from his drawer. Walks up to the door and proceeds to secure it with the padlock. He then checks the next target on the list.

As he checks he notices several names on the top of the list now have "DECEASED" in the Notes section of the list.

ANIRUDH
Ye maine kab likha?

As he clicks on them they disappear. He then dials the next number. Call connects.

CALLEE
Hello kaun?

ANIRUDH
Hello, main Inspector Vijaya bol rha hu CBI ke Cybercrime Division se. Kya meri baat Usman ji se ho rhi hai?

CALLEE
Ji bol rha hu?

ANIRUDH
Usman ji mujhe ek case file pa assign kiya gaya hai jispe ki aapka naam saamne aaya hai.

CALLEE
(Static and Garbled voice)
Yahi kahan tha na tune Patelji se bhi?

ANIRUDH
(Flabbergasted)
Kya? Ye kya bol rhe hain?

CALLEE
(Distressed)
Sab yaad hai mujhe.

Anirudh is speechless. Then blinks and suddenly his laptop is not there in front of him anymore. But he is wearing his headphone with its cord disconnected.

Voices comes from the headphones.

VOICES
Inspector sahab, sab yaad hai mujhe.
Aap ko toh OTP chahiye bus.
Please humein arrest mat kijiyega.

He checks the headphone cord that is now disconnected from the laptop. He gets scared. He starts looking around. His laptop is not there in his room. He looks outside from his window. And the laptop is sitting on the broken chair outside his room. Anirudh is confused.

ANIRUDH
Saala kya ho rha hai mere saath ye?

He garbs is key and unlocks the door. He goes and picks up the laptop. [The shawl should be missing from the wire this time around] While he is doing this, something behind him enters his room. Anirudh does not see this. he returns back and locks the room again from inside.

Before he sits he notices the shawl inside the room near the window.

ANIRUDH
Ab ye kaise andar aaya?

He uses the stick to lift the shawl and tosses it out of his window. He then returns to his laptop.

Anirudh then checks the final entry on the list, it says: Anirudh G and shows his number.

INT. ROOFTOP ROOM - NIGHT

Anirudh picks up his phone and calls his manager.

ANIRUDH
Hello sir.

SUPERVISOR
Hanji Anirudh bhai, kya hua?

ANIRUDH
Sir, ye mera naam list pe kyon hai?

SUPERVISOR
Han? Kya bol rhe ho? Tumhara naam kyon hoga list pe?

ANIRUDH
Sir, ispe Anirudh G likha hai and this looks like my number.

SUPERVISOR
Toh tum keh rhe ho poori duniya bus tum hi ek Anirudh G ho?

ANIRUDH
But sir, ye number...

SUPERVISOR
Bhai tumne Ganja phoonk liya hai kya? Kya ulta seedha bol rhe ho?

ANIRUDH
Nhi sir, pata nhi kya ho rha hai. But lag rha hai ye mera number.

SUPERVISOR
Abe phone kar aur dekh le na? Kya time kharab kar rha hai mera.

ANIRUDH
Sir kuch theek nhi lag rha mujhe. Ajeeb cheezein ho rhi hain mere saath.

SUPERVISOR
Sun mere bhai, ek ehsaan kar mere upar. Aakhri harvest bacha hai tera. Kar le aur kaam khatam kar de. Please, aur nhi ho rha hai mujhse.

ANIRUDH
Suniye toh sir, Kuch toh bohot ajeeb sa hi ho rha hai yahan.

SUPERVISOR
(Voice getting Garbled)
Last harvest bacha hai tera...
List khatam kar de Anirudh...

ANIRUDH
Kya hua sir?

Call disconnects.

ANIRUDH
Hello? Hello?

Anirudh puts the phone down.

PHONE
(Garbled Voice)
List khatam kar...

ANIRUDH
What the fuck? Ye kya tha?

[Start hanging the entity down secretly from mid of the above dialogue sequence] At the corner of his eye he sees the shawl and a face slowly hanging down from the top of his door. Anirudh grabs his flashlight again and shines light on the door, it immediately makes a sudden movement and flies to the right side.

And from the right side of the window a shawl comes flying inside the room. Anirudh panics and dives to the left side of the room. His headphone cord rips from his laptop and his phone drops to the right side. As he goes to the corner of the door he sees some entities standing inside his room at the far end near the cooler.

Scared, he looks around the room and the door. He gets up, picks up the door key and goes near the door. He tries opening but sees that the lock is on the other side of the door. He realizes he is trapped in the room.

ANIRUDH
Oh fuck. Kya karun, kya karun mai!
Phone kahan gaya mera.

He looks for his phone but its not there with him.

VOICES
Kaam poora kijiye Inspector sahab.
Aakhri harvest bacha hai aapka.

Anirudh huddles at the corner of the room.

VOICES
(Loudly)
ANIRUDH!

Sudden voice from his left outside the door startles him. [There is a face outside the door when this happens, it immediately disappears]

The laptop is just outside the door with the headphone and mouse connected to it. Anirudh looks at it for few seconds.

He then grabs the mouse and dials Emergency number on the dialer. Someone picks up on the other side.

SUPERVISOR
Hello, Anirudh? Fir se kyon call kiya? Report daal di tune?

ANIRUDH
What? No sir! Maine aapko nhi call kiya! Mai toh... Mai toh... ye Emergency no pe call kiya.

SUPERVISOR
Are you out of your mind? Abe dimaag sahi me kharab ho gaya hai kya tumhara?

ANIRUDH
Nhi Sir! Baat samajhiye. Mai apne hi room me lock ho gaya hu sir. I need help, mujhe samajh me nhi aa rha hai kya karun.

SUPERVISOR
(Voice getting Garbled)
Maine kaha na List khatam karne ko... List khatam kar de Anirudh...

Anirudh hangs up. He grabs his head in distress. He opens the dialer and slowly types in the number and hesitantly presses Dial.

Silence hangs for 15-20 seconds. Then his personal phone starts ringing. Anirudh leans to see. It's sitting midway between him and the entities standing at the corner of his room. He slowly removes the headphone from his head.

Anirudh slowly starts crawling towards the phone. The camera perspective shifts and now we see from the other end Anirudh crawling towards the camera. Something pushes the mobile towards Anirudh from behind the camera.

Anirudh looks at his phone. Caller ID says Unknown Number. Anirudh slowly picks up.

ANIRUDH
Hel...Hello?

VOICE
(Same sound as Anirudh)
Hello, main Inspector Vijaya bol rha hu CBI ke Cybercrime Division se. Kya meri baat Mr. Anirudh-ji se ho rhi hai?

ANIRUDH
(Panicking)
Kya? Kaun bol rha hai?

Anirudh leans left and sees the headphone wire stretched to somewhere outside the door. He can't see who is wearing it.

VOICE
Inspector sahab aap ke upar case file hua hai.

ANIRUDH
Nhi nhi nhi. Ye nhi ho sakta.
Kaise? Ye nhi ho sakta.

VOICE
Aapko OTP share karna hoga.

Anirudh's phone buzzes. There is an OTP on his phone. Anirudh hesitates. The entities are now much closer to him.

VOICE
OTP share kijiye Anirudh ji.

Entities are suddenly almost next to him.

ANIRUDH
5221... (Inaudible)

The moment he speaks the OTP everything goes quiet. The room is completely empty. Anirudh drops his phone. Then he slowly gets up. The metal door next to his room is now wide open.

He goes near the laptop. The status next to his name now says "Harvest Complete". On the wooden chair there is a shawl and the headphones on top of the shawl.

Anirudh is about to step out but he hears something and pauses and looks to his right. And the moment he raises a foot to step out at strange person appears in front of him with his eyes gouged out.

FADE OUT